

To see what Aristotle is thinking, let's look at two propositions about a possible future free action of yours.

The law of the excluded middle

For any proposition P , either P is true or Not- P is true.

So it must be that, if the law of the excluded middle is true, then one of these claims is true, and one of them is false.

But to endorse this is just to believe in fate, since it is to say that there is now a truth about whether you will get married on that day.

And nothing depended on this particular choice of an example. So,
for any possible future action of yours, there is now a truth about
whether and when you will perform it.

You will not get married
on June 1, 2027.

You will get married on
June 1, 2027.

We might call this the logical argument for fate:

1. For any proposition P , either P is true or $\text{Not-}P$ is true. (Law of the Excluded Middle)
2. Either it is true that you will get married on 6/1/30 or it is true that you will not get married on 6/1/30.
(1)

C. There are now truths about what you will do on 6/1/30.
(2)

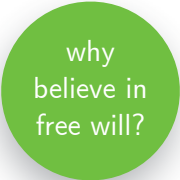
THE LOGICAL ARGUMENT FOR FATE



two
arguments
against free
will



is fate
real?



why
believe in
free will?



three
ways out

To see what Aristotle is thinking, let's look at two

propositions about possible future free action of yours.



The Law of the Land

For any proposition P , either P is true or Not- P

indivisible.

of these claims is true, and one of them is false.

So it must be that, if the law of the excluded middle is true, then

But to endorse this is just to believe in fate, since it is to say that

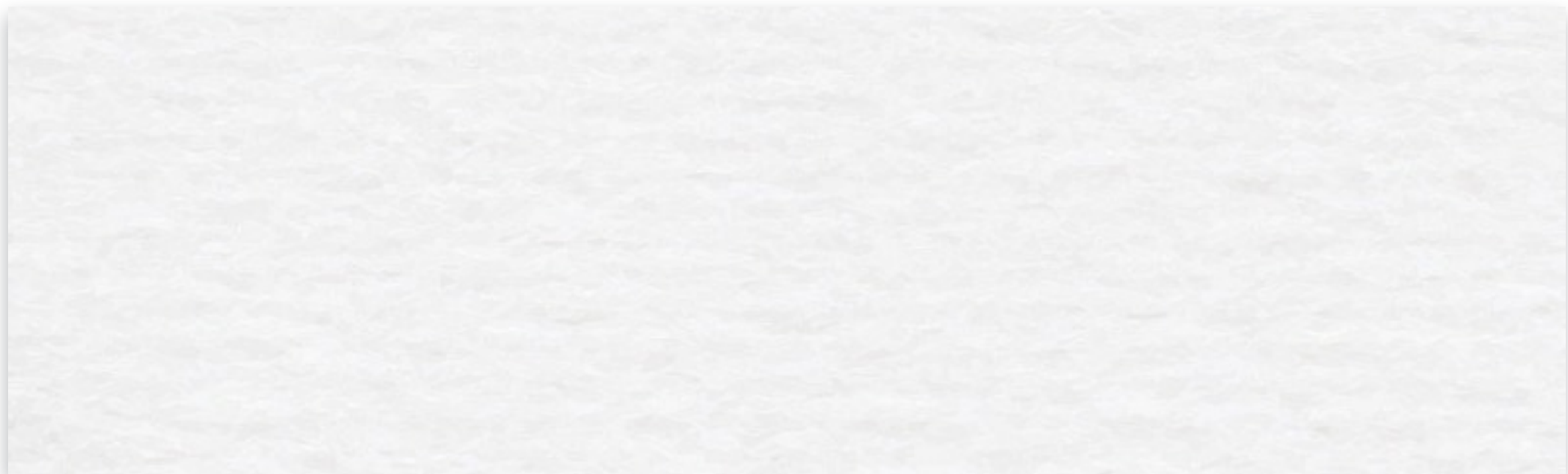
day.

there is no truth about whether you will get married or that

And nothing depends on this particular choice of an example. So,

whether and when you will perform it.

for any possible future action of yours, there is now a truth about



(2)

or it is true that you will not get married on 6/1/30.

trial (Lawful Mind)

1. For any proposition P , either P is true or $\text{Not-}P$ is



C. There are now truths about what you will do on 6/1/30.



2. Either it is true that you will get married on 6/1/30



We'll shortly consider some ways of

first let's think about how Edwards'

for fatalsn.

argument might be related to an argument

responding to Edwards' argument. But

there were truths about all our future

Edwards' argument — but did believe that

God— and hence rejected premise (2) of

actions. Could they give an argument

Suppose that someone did not believe in

similar to Edwards' argument?

replace reference to God's foreknowledge

(5) Let's look at what happens if we

God only shows up in premises (2) and

our future actions.

with reference to the being of truth about



4. If we have no choice about p , and no

choice about the fact that if p , then q ,

acaioid.

that if it is true that I will perform

all of our activities.

3 We have not the fact that

(3, 4, 5)

1. We have no direct facts.

5* We have noticed that the fact

will perform various actions.

perform a certain action (1,2)

some action, then I will prefer that

0 We have achieved what we

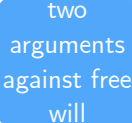
then we have the choice about q.

2* In the past, there were truths about



God knows that in the future I will

The fatalist argument



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So now consider a possible scenario in which someone exactly like you would get

a Predictor. By the above line of thought, this person would lack free will. But

that Predict did not **take away** their free will; it just shows them that they

never had any. So they lacked free will before getting a Predicto.

But this person was stipulated to be exactly like you. So you don't have free will,

either.

So far we've looked at two imaginary thought experiments—the story of Osmo,

things as fate, then there is no free will.

and the example of the Predictor — which seem to show that if there is such a

Our question is: do either fatigue or foreknowledge pose a

serious challenge to the reality of free will?

freedom that comes from fate.

Our first topic today is the oldest challenge to the existence of free will: the challenge to